

# Cards and Community: Social Connection in (the) Flesh and Blood

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# ✧ AGENDA ✧

Background, History, and Motivation

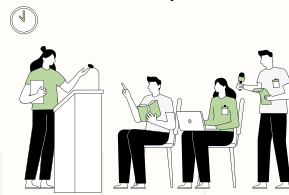
Effects of the COVID-19 pandemic

Empirical Study Overview

Participant Insights

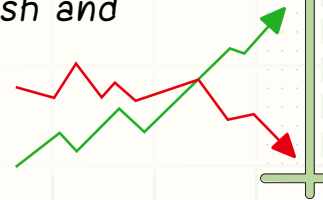
Findings

Implications



# ✧ A SHORT RECENT HISTORY ✧ OF TRADING CARD GAMES

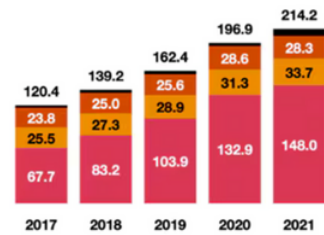
- The Big Three: *Magic: The Gathering* (1993), *Pokémon* (1996), *Yu-Gi-Oh!* (1999)
- The COVID-19 pandemic's effects on the industry
- New trends: Virtual worlds vs. *In the Flesh and Blood* (2019)



# VIDEO GAMES AND THE PANDEMIC

Total global video games revenue, by segment (US\$bn)

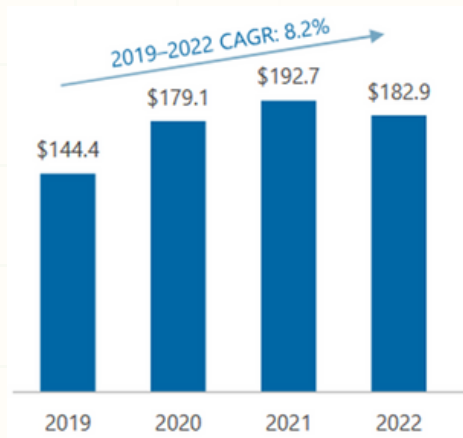
■ Social/casual gaming ■ PC games ■ Console games  
■ Integrated video games advertising



(World Economic Forum 2022)

- Until 2019: Steady growth in players and revenue, around 10% per year
- During the pandemic, revenue and playerbases spiked up: 26% growth in 2 years
- The pandemic is considered the most important factor for the video game industry's growth in recent years, as games provide escapism and fill time

# VIDEO GAMES AND THE PANDEMIC

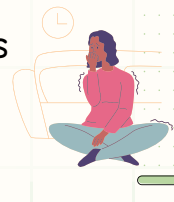


Video Game Market in \$B  
(Houlihan Lokey 2024, 6)

- Post-pandemic: markets normalized
- 2021 = peak, 2022 had 5% less revenue than 2021, playerbases continue to grow, but slower
- How do these trends compare to trading card games?

# HYPOTHESES AND PREDICTIONS?

- Video games boomed, but in-person gathering opportunities were limited or even illegal
- People lost their jobs or had to make financial budget cuts
- More time for hobbies and trying out new things at home





# MAGIC: THE GATHERING



- 50 million players worldwide (Hasbro Inc. 2022, 7), 6000 WPN stores (Wizards of the Coast 2019)
- New Digital Version! *Magic: The Gathering Arena* (2018), 13 million players (Draftsim 2025)
- During the pandemic, sales increased slightly, in-store play was not possible, moved to the digital version ("FNM at home")



# LITERATURE ABOUT MAGIC'S COMMUNITY

"[...] members have always felt welcome within the community (87%) and feel that it is inclusive to difference (90%) [...] observed and reported phenomenon of non-white, non-male players being looked down upon in Magic play spaces."  
(Barrett 2017, vi)

"[...] Magic occupies a unique space on the continuum between audience/fan control and producer control [...] Wizards of the Coast has a large influence and control over the community. I argue that the company's extensive work cultivating an infrastructure for Magic is one of the factors leading to its success and popularity."  
(Limbert 2012, 101)



# POKÉMON



- Highest revenue of any TCG by far, in Japan (where data is available)
- Demand boomed during the pandemic, especially in secondary markets. Likely due to audiences of adults with disposable income and nostalgia finding a new hobby of collecting cards.
- In-person play reemerged after the pandemic, as the game became much more popular. New digital version launched as an app in 2024.

"It's like a men's shed. People catch up, they see their friends, they have a chat. It's like their mental health weekly get-together." (Jackson 2025, §11)



# YU-GI-OH!



- Organized physical play vanished during pandemic, but digital version *Yu-Gi-Oh! Duel Links* (2016) hit record numbers (150M downloads) and revenue (Konami Digital Entertainment 2023).
- Tournaments were held via video conferences. After the pandemic, events reopened and had success, but no significant growth.
- However, research shows that the pandemic had an overall positive impact on the game, as the company shifted focus on the digital version (Bicheno 2022).



# FLESH AND BLOOD



- Released in 2019, right before the pandemic. Designed to be played in person, as a response to the digitalization of trading card games.
- During the pandemic, in-person events were not allowed. Small tournaments were played through video calls.
- Big events reopened in 2021, breaking records. Around 20k competitively active players in 2023 (Tabletop Gaming 2023).

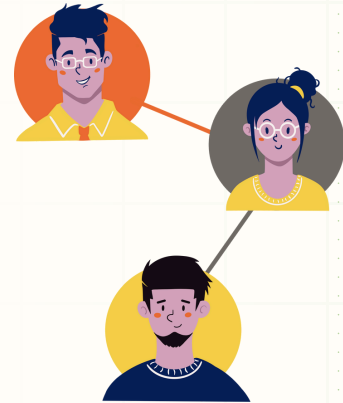
# PSYCHOLOGICAL IMPACTS OF THE PANDEMIC

- Mental health struggles for the general population due to social isolation.
- Neurodivergent people were struggling even more, with increased anxiety, depression, disrupted routines, and isolation (Corbett et al. 2021; Rogers and MacLean 2023).
- Research calls for "inclusive policies that enhance resilience, access to services, and social integration" (Gálvez et al. 2025, 1216).



# OUR THEORY

Trading card game tournaments and meet-ups serve as third spaces for players to connect with others, especially for neurodivergent people.





# STUDY OVERVIEW

# ✧ METHOD ✧



## Survey Design

- Anonymous Google Form
- Mix of multiple-choice & open-ended questions



## Key Topics

- Emotional impact of playing
- Friendship and community building
- Motivation for in-person events
- Neurodivergence self-identification



## Incentive

- 6 random respondents received a special Flesh and Blood card as a thank-you

I focused on themes like the emotional impact of playing, what draws people to in-person events, and how friendships and community bonds form through the game. I also added a self-identification option to understand how players might relate to neurodivergence or social anxiety.

As a small thank-you, I randomly selected six respondents to receive a special Flesh and Blood promo card—this added a bit of fun and encouraged more participation.”



# SURVEY OVERVIEW

 Exploratory survey

 May–June 2025

 36 participants (via FaB whatsapp chats)

 Mixed quantitative and qualitative questions

# DEMOGRAPHICS



**Average Age: 30.8 (Range: 18–51)**

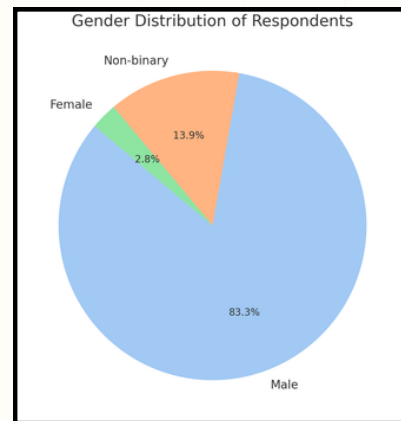


**Most Common Countries: Austria (26), Spain (8), Germany (1), Catalonia (1)**



**Gender Distribution**

**Gender diversity was present, but most respondents identified as male**

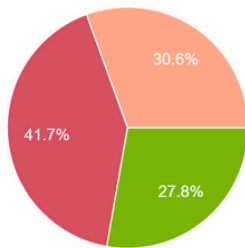


Here's a quick look at who responded to the survey. Most respondents were based in Austria, with a few from Spain and neighboring countries. The average age was just over 30, but we had a nice range from 18 to 51.

Even in general FaB spaces, every NB respondent identified as ND. All NT respondents were male, suggesting a gendered gap in neurodivergence self-awareness and participation.

This was a small, self-selecting sample, so not representative of the global community, but still telling.

# NEURODIVERGENCE SELF-IDENTIFICATION



● Yes  
● No  
● Maybe  
● Prefer not to say

📄 Some participants mentioned formal diagnoses (ADHD, autism, dyslexia, schizoaffective disorder, Tourette's), while others are still exploring or awaiting diagnosis.

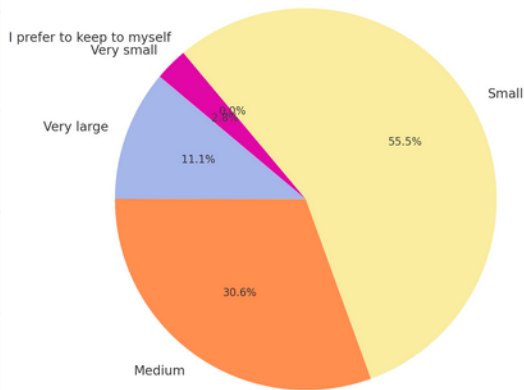
🌀 Many responses included uncertainty ("maybe," "still figuring it out," "not sure")

💬 ADHD and autism were the most frequently self-identified or suspected forms of neurodivergence.

🧠 A few participants also mentioned chronic depression, anxiety, or schizophrenia alongside neurodivergent identities.

These aren't diagnostic stats—just self-perceptions and explorations—but the language people used already says a lot about their needs and experiences.

## ✧ MAGIC SOCIAL CIRCLE ✧



🔄 Many participants mentioned changes in their social life due to moves, life transitions, or distance.

👤👩 Most maintain a few close friendships, prioritizing deeper connections over large networks.

📺 For several participants, their fab group is the main or only active circle.

🌐 Social ties often span offline, online, and hobby-based communities.

😞 Some mentioned introversion, difficulty making friends, or social fatigue.

When a third of respondents say they struggle to make friends, it really underscores the importance of safe, structured communities like FaB.

# FRIENDSHIP HABITS

🎲 **THROUGH HOBBIES OR GAMES – 28 OUT OF 36 (77.8%)**

👤 **At school or work – 18 out of 36 (50%)**

😞 **I find it difficult to make friends – 11 out of 36 (30.6%)**



## REFLECTIONS ON EARLY SOCIAL EXPERIENCES



🗨️ Only 25% of participants described their school years as mostly positive without qualifiers.

👁️ **The majority had mixed or difficult social experiences, with many expressing feelings of exclusion or disconnect**

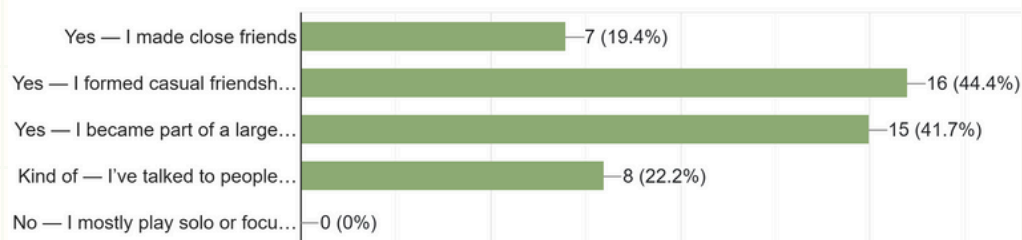
😬 36% said they **masked** or hid parts of themselves to fit in.

😬 40% **struggled with making friends** during school. Some shared experiences of bullying

Interpretation: This background sheds light on why the FaB community might be impactful: For those who felt like outsiders, finding a welcoming hobby community in adulthood can be life changing. It's a space where shared interest replaces the need for small talk or "fitting in."

Those who masked in school might feel they can be themselves at a game night. You come as a player of FaB, a role equal to everyone else at the table, and the focus is on the game, not on social performance. This structured context can ease social interaction, as research on RPGs has similarly noted: players engage in social interactions through fictional roles, in a secure environment governed by shared rules – with reduced risks and clearer expectations. In FaB, you're not literally role-playing a character, but you are adopting the role of a fellow gamer, following agreed rules, which can be comforting for the socially anxious.

# ✧ SOCIAL IMPACT OF PLAYING FRESH AND BLOOD ✧



- 👉 Casual friendships or local connections – 44%
- 🌐 Became part of a larger community – 42%
- ❤️ Made close friends – 19%
- 👥 Some connection, but no lasting contact – 22%

# ✧ FAB TRAVELLING ✧

✈️ **58.3% of respondents have traveled outside their region to attend a FaB event. Out of these:**

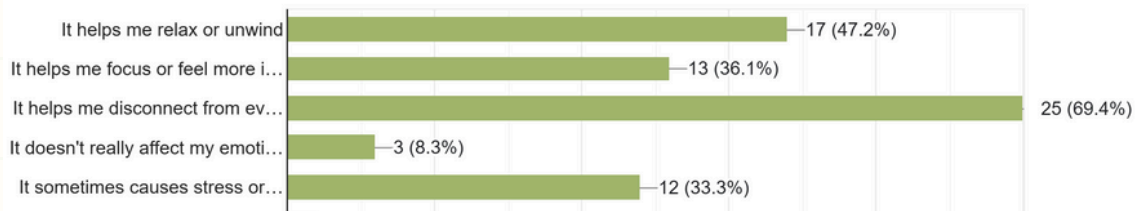
- 17% made new friends or joined new communities through travel
- 39% had some social contact while traveling, but didn't stay in touch

## FAVORITE TRAVEL MOMENTS

- 🗣️ "I love using different languages during matches — and people come up to me because they recognize me from previous events."
- 🚗 "The drives to the events are usually very fun... "
- 🌍 "Last year I went to Osaka for Worlds — met people from around the globe, shared an apartment with a player I'd met before."
- 💬 "Carpooling and lunch after tournaments always makes me feel more connected."
- ❤️ "My first large TCG event — Worlds in Barcelona — it was everything I hoped it would be."



## ✧ EMOTIONAL IMPACT ✧



🎯 Most respondents (70%) use FaB as a way to **disconnect** from everyday worries.

🧘 Half of the respondents say the game helps them **relax** or unwind.

🧩 36% report feeling more **focused** or in control while playing.

😬 33% also said that FaB sometimes causes **stress** or anxiety.

However, one participant noted that this stress can feel positive/motivating, unlike work stress.

*Importantly, no one reported a strongly negative emotional overall impact. Even those who feel stress occasionally also cited positive aspects.*

### Slide 8: Emotional Impact of Play

•

**Positive Emotions & Focus:** Playing FaB was reported to have several positive emotional effects:

**Escapism/Stress Relief:** The most common response (about 69% of players) was that FaB “helps me

disconnect from everyday worries.” For almost half, it also “helps me relax or unwind.”

This speaks to the

game as a mental break and a form of self-care or stress relief.

**Concentration & Control:** ~36% said it “helps me focus or feel more in control.”

Particularly for

neurodivergent players (like those with ADHD), the structured challenge of the game can be

engaging in a comforting way – providing clear goals and immediate feedback. Research in game

based therapy notes that structured gameplay can increase engagement and improve concentrati on

**Anticipation:** A few mentioned it gives something to look forward to each week – that sense of

anticipation and excitement for the next meetup or tournament is a motivational emotional boost i n

itself.

Negative/Complex Emotions: It's not all zen:

Competitive Stress: ~33% acknowledged "It sometimes causes stress or anxiety." This is unsurprising high-stakes matches or the drive to win can be intense. Some respondents mentioned feeling nervous before big games or upset after losses. However, many also indicated they are learning to handle these emotions. FaB's community ethos of sportsmanship may help here – players strive to remain positive and make the game fun for both sides. One article by a top FaB player notes: "No matter the case... I focus on the person across from me... I want them to walk away with a good experience, win or lose"

, emphasizing emotional resilience and camaraderie over raw victory.

"No Effect": A small minority (~8%) said the game doesn't really affect my emotions. These might be players who approach it very analytically or casually without strong emotional investment.

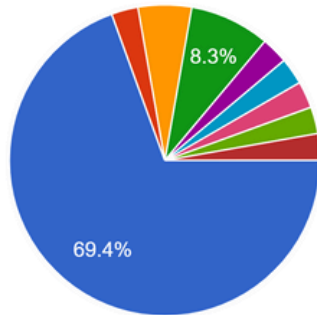
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Emotional Safety: Importantly, no one reported strongly negative emotional impact overall.

Even those who feel occasional stress also cited positive aspects. Many described FaB as a mood lifter or a focus aid. Given that some struggled socially in the past, finding an activity that brings joy and confidence can be profound.

## SOCIAL ENCOURAGEMENT IN FAB

✂ 25 participants (70%) said FaB's in-person format encourages them to connect with others more than other games.



- Yes — the in-person format helps me connect with people
- Kind of — I like the community, but I'd...
- Not really — I would prefer to play onli...
- I haven't played many other games
- Regarding TCGs, I don't think fab enc...
- Same way as other TCG's
- No, I feel the community we have doe...
- The community seems more open an...
- I don't see a strong difference. But to...

## ✦ PERSONAL REFLECTIONS ON FLESH AND BLOOD ✦



*"It has pretty much changed my life — I've made lots of friends, traveled to many different countries, and it helped me a lot through hard times"*

*"Even if I'd consider it to be a minimal part of my life, it's always a safe and known place to go back to. And all of it because of the people that are a part of it."*



*"I'd still rather play online if there was ranked... it's a weird dynamic — if I win I'm happy and they're upset, and if I lose I'm upset and they're happy."*

Let me end this section with some words from participants themselves—because I couldn't say it better.

## ✧ FINDINGS: PATTERNS IN SELF-PERCEPTION ✧

⚙️ **Not all “neurotypical”** respondents shared neurotypical experiences

🌈 All **non-binary** participants also self-identified as neurodivergent

👤 Most participants who reported **making close friendships** were either ND or potentially ND

🏫 Every participant who described **school as a wholly positive experience** also identified as neurotypical, reinforcing how exclusion often intersects with ND traits.



One thing we noticed was that the line between neurotypical and neurodivergent experiences wasn't always clear-cut.

For instance, even among those who marked “no” for neurodivergence, many described school experiences that closely mirror what ND players reported: masking, social exhaustion, and bullying. So the distinction between “self-identified NT” and “clinically neurotypical” is blurrier than the checkbox suggests.

We also saw a strong overlap between gender diversity and neurodivergence: every non-binary participant placed themselves on the ND spectrum, and every respondent who identified as neurotypical was male. This points to larger patterns in who opts into community research and who has exposure to ND language.

Finally, a few people joined mostly for the card promo—but they still completed every question, offering us insight even in their brevity.

## ✦ WHY ND PLAYERS THRIVE ✦ IN FaB COMMUNITIES

🧠 ~1/3 of respondents identified as neurodivergent (ND)

📊 Almost 60% (!) of participants were ND **AND** potentially ND

👉 Most ND players reported increased connection & belonging



### Why FaB works for ND players:

🧩 Structured Play (rules, scripts, etiquette)

🎯 Shared Goals (win conditions, fairness)

☀️ Special Interests (strategy, deckbuilding)

🛡️ Inclusive Culture (moderation, relatively beginner-friendly)

👥 Connection (ritual, co-presence)

Around a third of participants identified as neurodivergent—autistic, ADHD, or otherwise—and their responses highlighted both the strengths and challenges of social connection through FaB.

One theme was structured interaction. ND individuals often thrive in predictable environments with clear rules, and FaB provides exactly that. One person put it frankly: “If I win, I’m happy and they’re upset; if I lose, I’m upset and they’re happy. It’s a weird dynamic.”

Yet even this person kept attending events, showing that structured competitive play can still be meaningful—even for those who don’t usually enjoy human interaction.

Another key point was that most ND respondents felt more socially connected through FaB, especially due to shared interests, travel opportunities, and the feeling of being “part of something.”

Lastly, FaB resonates with the idea of a “safe space via structure.” Like many tabletop games, it offers a “scripted” kind of socializing—sit down, introduce yourself, play by shared rules. This predictability reduces ambiguity, which is often a source of anxiety. As one therapist put it:

“Games simulate real-life interactions in a structured environment... encouraging social connection.”

One takeaway from this study is that communities like Flesh and Blood can serve as models for ND-friendly design in games and spaces.

First, clear etiquette and defined roles—like calling a judge, shaking hands, or the emphasis on sportsmanship—provide a visible social script. These predictable interactions help ND players feel more confident navigating social situations. It externalizes social norms, which are often implicit and confusing for neurodivergent folks.

Second, the game's depth offers fertile ground for special interests. Whether it's lore, strategy, or card design, ND individuals who are passionate about games can find fulfilling avenues for expression and shared enthusiasm. Players mentioned drawing fan art, sharing deck ideas, and connecting over game mechanics.

Finally, community moderation and ethos are vital. Having zero tolerance for harassment, plus proactive inclusion, makes all the difference. It's not just the game mechanics, but the social tone set by organizers and fellow players that helps people feel safe enough to participate.

# FAB & THE VALUE OF “THIRD PLACES”



- 👥 Third place theory → FaB offers routine, social purpose
- 🏠 Community hubs → Game stores = accessible, welcoming venues
- 🏗️ Civic insight → Game spaces have public health and urban planning value
- 🧠 Affinity groups → FaB shows how culture, language, and identity form

Sociologist Ray Oldenburg coined the idea of ‘third places’—spaces that aren’t home or work, but where community thrives. For many, local game stores are that space.”

Many respondents mentioned how their local game store or FaB event served as a kind of “third place”—a social hub that isn’t home or work, but still feels like it belongs to them.

One store owner even said they explicitly set up their shop to be “a third place for the community”. In an era when traditional third places like cafés or clubs are in decline, game venues like these help fill that gap.

This has implications beyond just games. Urban designers and community planners might consider supporting spaces like game cafés, hobby clubs, and local tournaments. Even the U.S. Surgeon General has called loneliness a public health epidemic—so supporting regular, structured play might be a low-cost, high-reward intervention for mental and social well-being.

Our small study suggests that these places do real social work, especially for folks who might not otherwise engage in public social life.

One thing our study highlights is that games are deeply social—they can bring together people across boundaries like age, profession, or nationality. For example, we saw university students connecting with older professionals and international players.



This taps into existing research on fandoms and game cultures. Magic: The Gathering is a great comparison: scholars found that players develop their own language, rituals, and even values. FaB is developing something similar—a mini-culture of its own.

There's also a contrast to be made between analog and digital games. FaB's success in fostering in-person social connection suggests that physical presence matters: sitting down at a table, taking turns, casual side-chat.

While digital games have strong communities, there's a kind of embodied sociality that might be harder to replicate online. So for researchers, this opens up exciting questions about what card games can offer socially that other games might not.

An affinity group is a group of people who come together based on shared interests, values, or characteristics, often to foster a sense of community, support, and collective action. These groups can be formal or informal, and their purpose can range from social connections to professional development or social and political activism

## ✦ BROADER IMPLICATIONS: COMMUNITY DESIGN ✦

- 🕒 Consistency builds connection → Weekly events create ritual and support lasting friendships.
- 🎯 Shared goals & social scripts reduce ambiguity → Clear expectations (e.g., respectful conduct, calling a judge, handshakes) help players feel safe and grounded.
- 🛡️ Inclusivity is designed, not automatic → Community culture depends on leaders, moderation, and shared norms, prioritizing cooperation alongside competition.



One major takeaway from our study is the power of consistency. Regular gatherings—like FaB’s weekly events—aren’t just about gameplay. They provide a rhythm that allows real friendships to form. From a community design perspective, this shows how ritual and repetition can become the scaffolding of people’s social lives.

Another insight is about structure: having a shared goal (the game) gives people something to focus on, which eases awkwardness. Explicit norms—like when to shake hands or call a judge—also reduce ambiguity, especially helpful for folks with social anxiety.

We also noticed a clear culture of respect and camaraderie, often upheld by community leaders like shop owners or TOs. Even though FaB is a competitive game, players often emphasize "fun with others" over pure winning. That’s not accidental—it’s part of the ethos that’s modeled and encouraged.

Lastly, we raise a question: as the game grows, can this close-knit, supportive atmosphere scale? More players might mean more subgroups or even risks of toxicity. It’s worth watching whether these positive outcomes persist or whether interventions (like intentional community-building) become necessary.





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